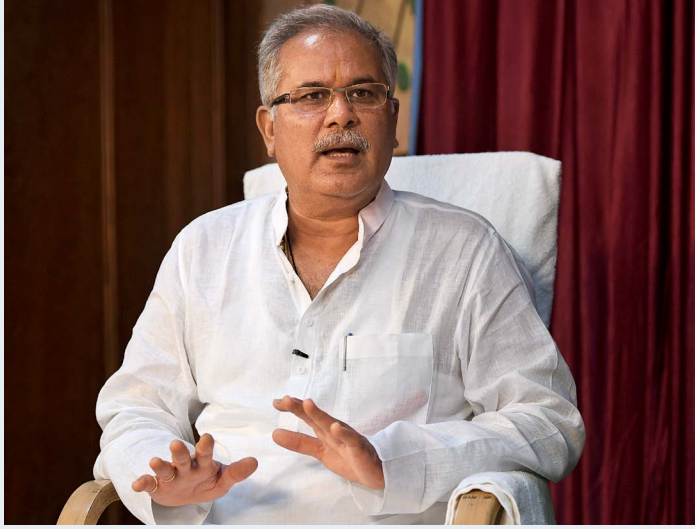
INTERVIEW | BHUPESH BAGHEL

'BJP has replaced gentle Ram with an aggressive version'



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Chhattisgarh CM **BHUPESH BAGHEL** *clears the air on a host of issues—from his relationship with his cabinet colleague T.S. Singh Deo to the raids of Central agencies on the state's officials and politicians—in an interview with Senior Associate Editor* **RAHUL NORONHA**. *Excerpts:*

Q. What are the key initiatives of your government on which you are seeking re-election in the upcoming assembly election?
Schemes that revolve around the welfare of farmers, the youth, workers (the non-landholding poor in rural areas) and women have been the focus areas of the government. We will go to the people on the basis of the work done for these groups.

Q. There is a lot of talk about your government pursuing 'soft Hindutva'. Do other communities have a place in this plan or is it exclusively for Hindus, and aimed at cutting into BJP votes?
All communities are being covered under these initiatives. We have been organising a national tribal dance festival for the last three years, and *dev gudis*, *mata gudis* (sacred sites of tribal communities) and *ghotuls* (youth dormitory) are being restored. For the Satnami community, who are SCs, sites revered by them like Lalpur and Giroudpuri Dham are being developed. Luthra Sahab, a prominent centre for Muslims, is also being developed. For the Buddhist community, Sirpur is being promoted. Ramayana and its reading are all-pervasive in Chhattisgarh. We organised a Ramayana narration competition to promote this. The issue is that the BJP has replaced the gentle version of Ram that we knew with an aggressive version. Secondly, Hanumanji, who is associated with *shakti*, *gyaan* and *bhakti*, has been turned into an 'Angry Birds' version. The BJP has attempted to alter the symbols of our faith. To reverse that, we are projecting Ram as Shabri Ke Ram and Vanvasi Ram, the versions of Ram that have been prevalent among the people of Chhattisgarh.

Q. The BJP alleges a scam in the kin of politicians and bureaucrats being recruited through the PSC exams.
If the BJP has complaints, they should submit proof and I will have it investigated.

Q. Why is the PM Awas Yojana lagging in Chhattisgarh?
My issue is that the allocation is being made on the

through the loans they extend, the social connect they have and the jobs they offer at their farms.

The Chhattisgarh government has also been pursuing a project of rural development called the 'Narwa, Garuwa, Ghurwa, Badi', which translates into development of water sources, livestock, compost and promotion of organic farming and small patches for crop cultivation. A novel initiative of the Baghel government has been procurement of cow dung and urine from cattle owners and the marketing of cow-based products like paints and *agarbattis* through a network of *gauthaans* (cattle resting places) across the state. Baghel's largesse also covers landless labourers, an important voting group in rural areas. As part of the Nyay scheme, they get Rs 6,000 per annum.

BAGHEL BELIEVES HIS FARM AND OTHER INITIATIVES WILL BE VOTE-CATCHERS, BUT INTRA-PARTY FIGHTING AND SLOWING DEVELOPMENT COULD SPOIL THE PARTY

Despite a history of relative communal harmony, Chhattisgarh has seen incidents of attacks on churches and Christians in the tribal-dominated Bastar region in the past few years. There have also been Hindu-Muslim riots in the Kabirdham and Bemetara districts in the central region. Muslims constitute around 2 per cent while Christians account for 1.92 per cent of the state's population. The Congress claims that the BJP is attempting a polarisation of Hindu votes by stoking tension. The Congress under Baghel has launched a programme to develop Hindu holy sites as centres of pilgrimage to promote religious tourism. It is also organising Ramayana recitation and Ramleela competitions right down to the village panchayat level. The